490.LIFE · THE WHOLE STORY · LESSON 1 OF 26

# The Story Jesus Told

*Luke 24:13–35, 44–47*



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## Introduction: Walking Home Without the Story

It was Sunday afternoon, and two people were walking home from the worst weekend of their lives.

Luke tells us one of them was named Cleopas. We never learn the other's name. They had followed Jesus of Nazareth. They had heard him teach and watched him heal, and they had come to believe he was the one God promised to send. Then, on Friday, they watched the authorities nail him to a Roman cross. By Sunday the whole thing was over, or so they thought. So they left Jerusalem and started the seven miles back to a village called Emmaus, talking it over the way grieving people do, going around and around the same few facts.

The strange thing about that walk is that they had all the facts. They knew Jesus was a prophet "mighty in deed and word." They knew he had been crucified. They had even heard that his tomb was empty that morning and that angels were saying he was alive. Every piece of the good news was already in their hands. And they were walking away from Jerusalem with their faces down, because they did not have the story that held the pieces together.

A lot of people meet the Bible that way. You may know a few pieces: a baby in a manger, a man and an ark full of animals, a verse on a coffee mug, a cross on a wall. Maybe you tried to read the Bible straight through once and got lost somewhere in the laws about mildew in Leviticus. The pieces never seemed to connect, so the Book felt like a pile of old religious writings that only experts could sort out.

This study is for you. Over twenty-six lessons we are going to walk through the whole Bible, from the first page to the last, and learn the one story it tells. We will put real dates on it so you can see when Abraham lived and when the temple was built. We will follow two threads that run all the way through it. And we are going to start where Jesus himself started when he wanted two confused disciples to understand their Bibles: on the road to Emmaus.

## The Word: He Interpreted

> **Luke 24:25–27** *"And he said to them, 'O foolish ones, and slow of heart to believe all that the prophets have spoken! Was it not necessary that the Christ should suffer these things and enter into his glory?' And beginning with Moses and all the Prophets, he interpreted to them in all the Scriptures the things concerning himself."*

The stranger who joined them on the road was Jesus himself, risen from the dead, though "their eyes were kept from recognizing him" (Luke 24:16). He let them pour out their disappointment. Then he did something they never expected. He could have started by showing them his hands. He opened their Bibles instead. And Luke chose a careful word for what he did with them:

### διερμηνεύω *(diermēneuō)*

*translated "he interpreted." To explain thoroughly; to carry the meaning across so it can be understood*

**διά** (dia)

*"through"*

All the way through, from one side to the other. In compound words it often means thoroughly.

+

**ἑρμηνεύω** (hermēneuō)

*"to interpret, to translate"*

To put meaning into words someone else can grasp. It gives us the word "hermeneutics," the study of how to interpret.

**Payoff:** The word shows up only six times in the New Testament, and the other uses show what it does. In Acts 9:36 it translates a name from Aramaic into Greek: "Tabitha, which, translated, means Dorcas." In 1 Corinthians 12 and 14 it is the gift of interpreting a language nobody in the room understands. Every time, it means carrying meaning across a gap. On the Emmaus road the gap ran between the words and their meaning. These two had grown up hearing the Scriptures. They had the words. What they lacked was the meaning, and Jesus carried it across to them, through the whole thing, from Moses to the Prophets: it was all about him.

Keep that word in your pocket for all twenty-six lessons. It describes exactly what this study is trying to do. We are asking the one who wrote the Bible to interpret it to us, the way he did on that road.

## Part One: "We Had Hoped"

> **Luke 24:19–21** *"And they said to him, 'Concerning Jesus of Nazareth, a man who was a prophet mighty in deed and word before God and all the people, and how our chief priests and rulers delivered him up to be condemned to death, and crucified him. But we had hoped that he was the one to redeem Israel.'"*

Listen to that phrase: "We had hoped." It is one of the saddest lines in the Bible. They are speaking in the past tense about the thing that should have been his greatest hope. He thought the cross was the end of the story. It never occurred to him that the cross might be the point of the story.

Why could he not see it? He had been told. Jesus had told his disciples plainly, more than once, that he would be handed over, killed, and raised on the third day (Luke 9:22; 18:31–33). The women had reported the empty tomb. Peter had seen the grave clothes. Cleopas had the facts and still walked away sad, because his idea of the Messiah had no room for a cross. (*Messiah* is Hebrew for "anointed one," the King God promised; *Christ* is the same word in Greek.) He was expecting a king who would throw off Rome. A crucified Messiah did not fit his story, so he concluded the story had failed.

Jesus' diagnosis is blunt, and it is also kind: "O foolish ones, and slow of heart to believe all that the prophets have spoken!" (24:25). Mark the word *all*. They believed some of what the prophets said. They loved the promises about a glorious king. They skipped the parts about a servant who would be "pierced for our transgressions" (Isa. 53:5). They had read the Bible in pieces, kept the pieces they liked, and so they missed the shape of the whole.

That is the danger this lesson is meant to guard you against. When you only know pieces of the Bible, you will fill the gaps with your own expectations. You will decide what God ought to be like and what he ought to do, and when life does not match, you will say, "We had hoped." The cure is the whole story, read the way its Author reads it.

## Part Two: Beginning with Moses

"Was it not necessary that the Christ should suffer these things and enter into his glory?" (24:26). The word *necessary* matters. Jesus is saying the cross was written into the plan from the beginning. So he starts "with Moses," which means the first five books of the Bible, and walks them through "all the Scriptures."

Later that same night he appeared to the rest of the disciples in Jerusalem and said it again, even more fully:

> **Luke 24:44–47** *"Then he said to them, 'These are my words that I spoke to you while I was still with you, that everything written about me in the Law of Moses and the Prophets and the Psalms must be fulfilled.' Then he opened their minds to understand the Scriptures, and said to them, 'Thus it is written, that the Christ should suffer and on the third day rise from the dead, and that repentance for the forgiveness of sins should be proclaimed in his name to all nations, beginning from Jerusalem.'"*

"The Law of Moses and the Prophets and the Psalms." Jesus' words match the three-part shape the Hebrew Bible still has: the Law (Genesis through Deuteronomy), the Prophets (Joshua, Judges, Samuel, and Kings, along with the prophets themselves), and the Writings, whose best-known book is the Psalms. English Bibles arrange the same books differently, as we will see in a moment. So when Jesus names all three, he is putting his hand on the whole Old Testament and saying, "This is about me."

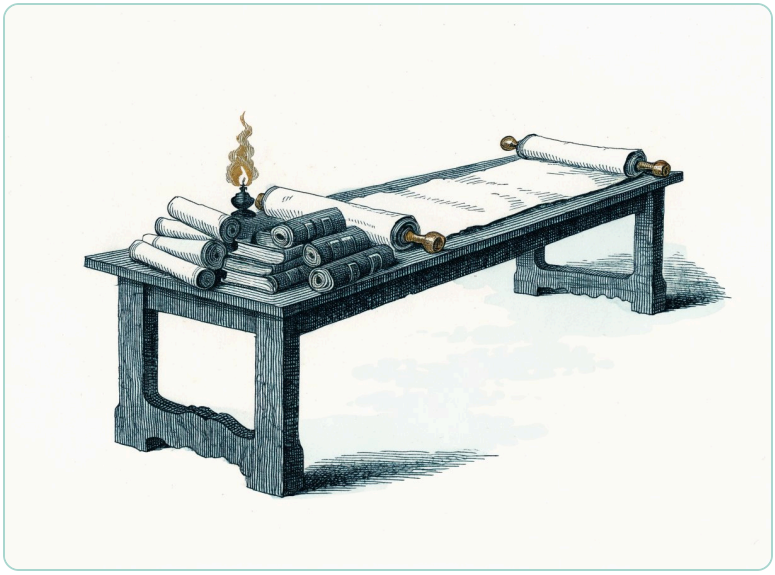
Think about what that means for how we read. Some Christians treat the Old Testament as a long preface they politely skim before getting to the good part. Jesus treated it as the first half of one story, aimed at him from its opening chapters. Augustine, the great North African pastor, put it in a line Christians have repeated for sixteen hundred years: "The New is hidden in the Old, and the Old is made plain in the New" (*Questions on the Heptateuch* 2.73).

The Reformers saw this clearly, and the Westminster Confession of Faith (a 1640s summary of what Scripture teaches, still used by Presbyterian churches; "WCF" from here on) puts it carefully. God's one way of saving sinners, which the Confession calls the covenant of grace (a covenant is a binding promise God makes to his people, sealed by his own word), was administered, or handed out, in two ways. In the time of the law it came through "promises, prophecies, sacrifices, circumcision, the paschal lamb, and other types and ordinances delivered to the people of the Jews, all foresignifying Christ to come" (WCF 7.5). In the time of the gospel it comes through the preaching of the Word and the sacraments. But "there are not therefore two covenants of grace, differing in substance, but one and the same, under various dispensations" (WCF 7.6).

Put plainly: Abraham, Moses, and David were saved the same way anyone is saved: by grace, through faith, in the Messiah God promised. The Confession says those old signposts were enough, by the Spirit's work, to build up God's people "in faith in the promised Messiah, by whom they had full remission of sins" (WCF 7.5). They looked forward to him. We look back to him. The lambs on the altar, the priests, the temple, the promises to David were all signposts, and every one of them pointed down the road to the same place. When you learn to see the signposts, the Old Testament stops being a maze. It becomes a road, and Jesus is walking it with you.

**Also read:** *John 5:39–40, 46; Acts 3:18; 1 Corinthians 15:3–4; 1 Peter 1:10–12; Romans 15:4*

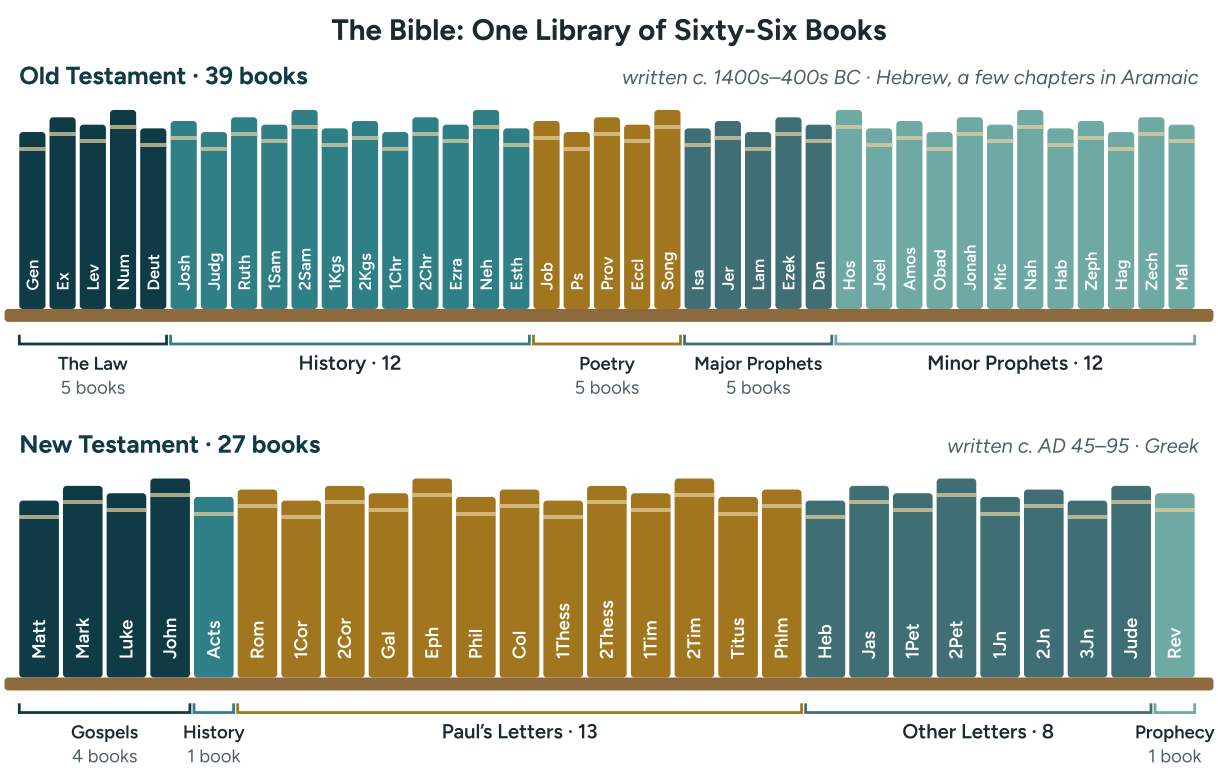
## Part Three: One Book Made of Sixty-Six



*Sixty-six books, written over roughly fifteen hundred years, laid end to end. They read as one scroll because one Author stands behind them all.*

If you are new to the Bible, it helps to know what you are holding. The word *Bible* comes from a Greek word for "books," and that is exactly what it is: a library of sixty-six books bound into one volume. Thirty-nine make up the Old Testament, written mostly in Hebrew (with a few chapters in Aramaic) before

Jesus was born. Twenty-seven make up the New Testament, written in Greek in the decades after his resurrection. “Testament” is an old word for covenant. The Old Testament is the story of God’s covenant promises. The New Testament is the story of those promises kept in Jesus and carried to the nations.




The books are grouped by kind, not strictly by date, which surprises a lot of new readers. The first shelf of the Old Testament is the Law: five books from creation to Moses. Then come twelve books of history, from Joshua entering the land to Nehemiah rebuilding Jerusalem’s walls. Then five books of poetry and wisdom, including the Psalms and Proverbs. Then the prophets, five “major” and twelve “minor,” named for their size (Lamentations rides with Jeremiah), who preached during the history you just read about. The New Testament follows a similar pattern: four Gospels telling the life of Jesus, one book of history (Acts), twenty-one letters to churches and pastors, and one book of prophecy (Revelation).

A practical word if you have never looked up a verse. A reference like Luke 24:27 means the book of Luke, chapter 24, verse 27. The authors did not write chapter and verse numbers. Those were added much later (chapters in the 1200s, verse numbers in the 1400s and 1500s) to help us find our place. Most Bibles have a table of contents in the front, and there is no shame in using it. Everyone does at first.

These sixty-six books were written by about forty different people across roughly fifteen hundred years, from Moses in the desert to the apostle John on the island of Patmos. They include shepherds, kings, a tax collector, a doctor, fishermen, and a tentmaker. They wrote in palaces and prisons, in Israel, Babylon,

and Rome. And they tell one story. That is because behind the many human authors stands one divine Author:

> **2 Timothy 3:16** *"All Scripture is breathed out by God and profitable for teaching, for reproof, for correction, and for training in righteousness,"*

> **2 Peter 1:21** *"For no prophecy was ever produced by the will of man, but men spoke from God as they were carried along by the Holy Spirit."*

Peter's word for "carried along" is the same verb Luke uses for a ship driven by the wind (Acts 27:15, 17). The writers really wrote. Their personalities, vocabularies, and circumstances show on every page. But the Spirit filled the sails, and he brought them all to the same harbor. The book of Hebrews opens by naming that harbor: "Long ago, at many times and in many ways, God spoke to our fathers by the prophets, but in these last days he has spoken to us by his Son" (Heb. 1:1–2). Many times, many ways, one Speaker, one final Word.

CORE DOCTRINE 1 OF 26 · SCRIPTURE ALONE

### The Authority of Scripture

The Bible is God's own word, written by human authors as the Holy Spirit carried them along. It is true in all it teaches, and it is the final authority over everything we believe and do. Traditions, feelings, and experts are tested by Scripture, never the other way around.

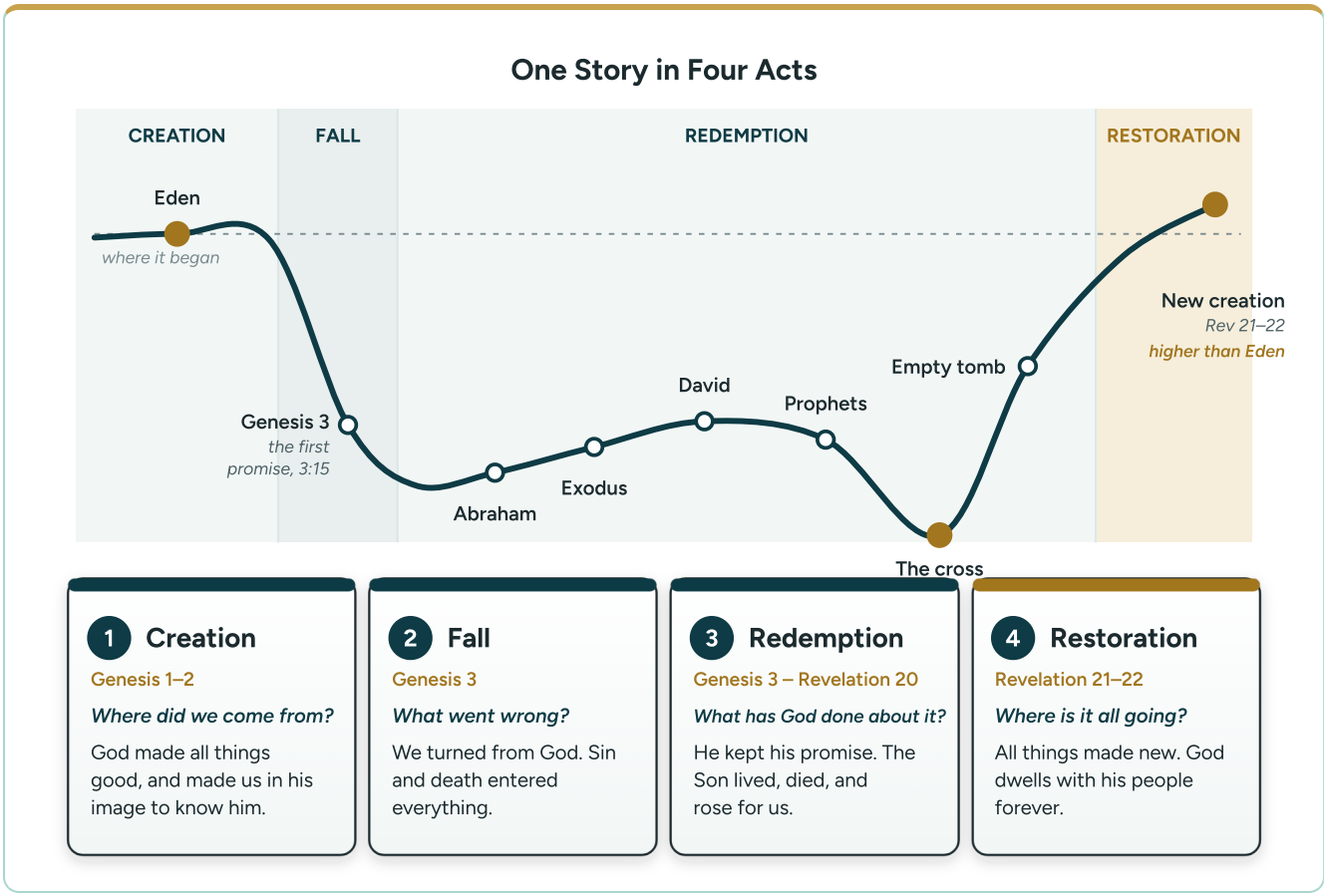
**KEY VERSES**
2 Timothy 3:16–17; 2 Peter 1:20–21; Luke 24:27, 44

**WHAT THE CHURCH CONFESSES**
*"The Word of God, which is contained in the Scriptures of the Old and New Testaments, is the only rule to direct us how we may glorify and enjoy him."* (Westminster Shorter Catechism 2)

**WHY IT MATTERS**
You do not have to guess what God is like or what he wants. He has spoken, and you can open his word and hear him for yourself.

## Part Four: The Whole Story in Four Acts

So what is the story? Before we spend twenty-five lessons on the details, you need the whole thing in one glance. Christians through the centuries have summed it up in four acts. Learn these four words and you will never be completely lost in the Bible again, because every page you read belongs to one of them.




**Act One: Creation.** "In the beginning, God created the heavens and the earth" (Gen. 1:1). Before anything else existed, God was. He made everything out of nothing, and he made it good. He made human beings in his own image, to know him, to love him, and to rule his world under him. And he came near to them. He placed them in a garden and spoke with them there (Gen. 2:15–22). Even after they sinned, they heard him walking in the garden (Gen. 3:8).

**Act Two: The Fall.** In Genesis 3 the first man and woman listened to a lying voice and reached for what God had forbidden. They wanted to be like God without God. Everything broke at once: their trust in God, their love for each other, their bodies, the ground they worked. Death entered the world, and every one of us has been born on this side of that door. And it goes deeper than the world around us. We are born with hearts bent away from God, and each of us adds our own sins to Adam's (Rom. 5:12). It is why the world feels the way it does.

**Act Three: Redemption.** Then comes the wonder: God did not abandon what he had made. In the same chapter where sin enters, he makes a promise: one born of the woman will crush the serpent's head, though the serpent will strike his heel (Gen. 3:15). The rest of the Bible, from Genesis 3 to Revelation 20, is the story of God keeping that promise. He chooses Abraham. He rescues Israel from Egypt. He gives the law and the tabernacle (a tent where he would live among them). He raises up David. He sends the prophets. And at last he sends his own Son, who lives the life we failed to live, dies the death we deserved, and rises again. Most of the Bible lives in this act, and so will most of our lessons.

**Act Four: Restoration.** The story does not end with the world as it is now. Jesus is coming back, and when he does he will make all things new. The last two chapters of the Bible show a new heaven and a new earth, and a voice from the throne says, "Behold, the dwelling place of God is with man. He will dwell with them, and they will be his people, and God himself will be with them as their God" (Rev. 21:3). He will also judge the world in righteousness, and the new creation belongs to those who belong to him (Rev. 21:7, 27). That is where it is all going.



*"A river flowed out of Eden to water the garden" (Gen. 2:10). "Then the angel showed me the river of the water of life" (Rev. 22:1). The Bible begins and ends beside the same river.*

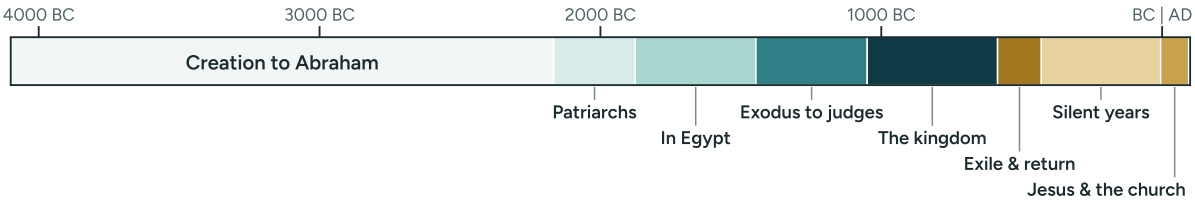
Look at how the Bible ends, because it tells you how the Bible begins. Genesis 2 has a garden, a river flowing out of it, and the tree of life in the middle. Revelation 22 has a river "bright as crystal, flowing from the throne of God and of the Lamb," and on either side of it, "the tree of life with its twelve kinds of fruit" (Rev. 22:1–2). The last page answers the first. Everything lost in the garden is restored, and more than restored. The garden has become a city, full of people from every nation, and "they will see his face" (22:4).

## Part Five: When It Happened

The Bible is not a book of myths that float free of history. It names kings we can find in Assyrian and Babylonian records. It gives ages, reigns, and the number of years between events. Luke opens his Gospel by telling us he "followed all things closely" and wrote "an orderly account" (Luke 1:3). God worked

in real time, in real places, with real people. So in this study we are going to keep a timeline in front of us the whole way.

## The Whole Story on One Timeline




*Drawn to scale. From Abraham on, the Old Testament story fills the last two thousand years before Christ.*

| WHEN | WHAT HAPPENED | READ | LESSON |
|---|---|---|---|
| c. 4100 BC | Creation; Adam and Eve in the garden | *Gen 1–3* | 3–4 |
| c. 2450 BC | The Flood; God's covenant with Noah | *Gen 6–9* | 5 |
| 2166 BC | Abraham born (called c. 2091 BC) | *Gen 12* | 6 |
| c. 1876 BC | Jacob's family moves to Egypt | *Gen 46* | 7 |
| 1446 BC | The Exodus; the first Passover | *Ex 12* | 8 |
| 1445 BC | The tabernacle is set up | *Ex 40:17* | 10 |
| c. 1406 BC | Joshua leads Israel into Canaan | *Josh 3* | 12 |
| c. 1375–1050 BC | The judges | *Judges* | 13 |
| 1010 BC | David becomes king (over all Israel c. 1003) | *2 Sam 2:4* | 14 |
| 966 BC | Solomon begins the first temple (done c. 959) | *1 Kgs 6* | 15 |
| 930 BC | The kingdom splits in two | *1 Kgs 12* | 16 |
| 722 BC | Northern Israel falls to Assyria | *2 Kgs 17* | 16 |
| 586 BC | Babylon destroys Jerusalem and the temple | *2 Kgs 25* | 17 |
| 538 BC | Cyrus lets the exiles go home | *Ezra 1* | 18 |
| 516/515 BC | The second temple is completed | *Ezra 6:15* | 18 |
| c. 430 BC | Malachi, the last Old Testament prophet | *Malachi* | 18 |
| c. 6–4 BC | Jesus born in Bethlehem | *Matt 2* | 19 |
| AD 30 or 33 | The cross and the empty tomb | *Luke 23–24* | 21–22 |
| AD 30 or 33 | Pentecost: the church begins | *Acts 2* | 23 |
| c. AD 46–57 | Paul's missionary journeys | *Acts 13–21* | 24 |
| AD 70 | Rome destroys the second temple | *Matt 24:1–2* | 25 |
| c. AD 95 | John writes Revelation on Patmos | *Rev 1:9* | 26 |

*Dates before Solomon count back from 1 Kings 6:1 and the ages in Genesis 5 and 11. Ussher (1650) dated creation to 4004 BC. Some read the genealogies with gaps, or place the Exodus near 1260 BC. Kings follow Thiele; most scholars agree within a decade.*

A word on how these dates are worked out. From the divided kingdom onward, Israel's kings can be checked against Assyrian and Babylonian records, and most scholars place Solomon within about a decade. This study uses Edwin Thiele's widely followed dates. Jerusalem fell to Babylon in 586 BC (some count 587). Solomon began building the temple in 966 BC. The Bible itself then gives us a bridge backward: Solomon started the temple "in the four hundred and eightieth year after the people of Israel came out of the land of Egypt" (1 Kings 6:1). Count back 480 years and you reach the Exodus in 1446 BC. A year later, "in the first month in the second year, on the first day of the month, the tabernacle was erected" (Ex. 40:17). That was the tent where God lived among his people in the wilderness, almost five hundred years before Solomon built the temple in stone.

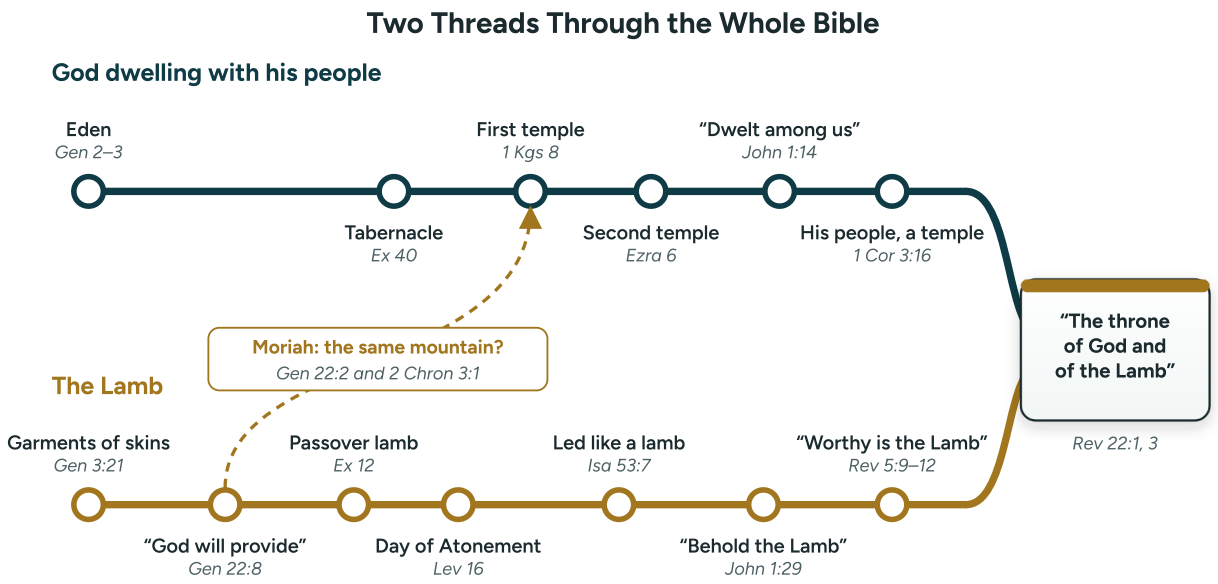
Before Abraham, the dates come from the ages listed in the family records of Genesis 5 and 11. Counted at face value, they put Adam roughly six thousand years ago and Noah's flood around 2450 BC, about forty-five hundred years ago. You may have heard of Archbishop James Ussher, who in 1650 dated creation to 4004 BC. He used the same method, but he read the 430 years of Exodus 12:40 as starting with Abraham's call instead of as Israel's time in Egypt. That shortens the count by about two centuries, which is the main reason his date runs about a century younger than ours.

You should know that faithful Christians, including Reformed ones, have read those early chapters differently. In 1890 the Princeton scholar William Henry Green argued that the genealogies in Genesis skip generations, the way Matthew's list of Jesus' ancestors does (Matthew 1:8 says "Joram the father of Uzziah," skipping three kings listed in 1 Chronicles 3:11–12). Others place the Exodus later, around 1260 BC. This study uses the dates you get by taking those numbers at face value, and where good Christians disagree we will say so honestly instead of pretending the question does not exist. What no faithful reader disputes is the part that matters most: Adam was a real man, the fall was a real event, and God's promises unfolded in real history until the Son of God was born in Bethlehem while Herod was king.

Every lesson from here on will open with a small "You are here" marker on this timeline. By the end you will be able to sketch it from memory, and when you read any page of the Bible you will know roughly where you are standing.

## Part Six: Two Threads to Follow

Long stories have threads, ideas that appear early, disappear for a while, and come back stronger. If you notice them, the story holds together. The Bible has many, but we are going to follow two of them from Genesis to Revelation, because together they carry the whole gospel.




*Both threads end in the same place. The God who dwells with his people is the God who provided the Lamb.*

**The first thread is God dwelling with his people.** In Eden God spoke with the man and woman he had made. After the fall, that closeness was lost, and the rest of the Bible is God making a way back. He came down to live in a tent in the middle of Israel's camp (the tabernacle). Solomon himself knew a building could not contain God (1 Kings 8:27). The tabernacle was the place God chose to meet with his people and show his presence among them. Then in a house of stone in Jerusalem (Solomon's temple). When that temple was destroyed, a smaller one was rebuilt after the exile. Then John writes a sentence no one expected: "And the Word became flesh and dwelt among us" (John 1:14). The word for "dwelt" means he pitched his tent among us. Jesus is where God lives with man. Now, through his Spirit, his people are called God's temple (1 Cor. 3:16). And at the end, "the dwelling place of God is with man" (Rev. 21:3). Garden to tent to temple to Jesus to the church to the city of God.

**The second thread is the Lamb.** When Adam and Eve sinned, God himself "made for Adam and for his wife garments of skins and clothed them" (Gen. 3:21). Something died so that their shame could be covered. From there the thread runs through Abel's offering, to Abraham on Mount Moriah telling his son, "God will provide for himself the lamb" (Gen. 22:8), to the Passover lamb whose blood marked the doors in Egypt, to the Day of Atonement, the one day each year when Israel's sins were covered, when the high priest carried blood behind the curtain into the Most Holy Place, the inner room of God's presence. Thousands upon thousands of animals died on Israel's altars. And yet the book of Hebrews says something startling: "For it is impossible for the blood of bulls and goats to take away sins" (Heb. 10:4). Those sacrifices were real, and God used them, but they were temporary. They were pointing at someone. When John the Baptist saw Jesus walking toward him, he said, "Behold, the Lamb of God, who takes away the sin of the world!" (John 1:29). And the song of heaven is this: "Worthy are you to take the scroll and to open its seals, for you were slain, and by your blood you ransomed people for God from every tribe and language and people and nation" (Rev. 5:9).

Watch for one more thing, because we will come back to it in Lesson 6. God sent Abraham to offer his son "on one of the mountains" in "the land of Moriah" (Gen. 22:2), and there God provided a ram instead. More than a thousand years later Solomon built the temple "on Mount Moriah" (2 Chron. 3:1). Jewish and Christian readers have long taken these as the same place. If they are, the two threads meet on one hill. Where God provided the sacrifice, God came to dwell. Every lesson will include a "Thread Watch" box showing where these two threads surface in that part of the story.

## The Turn: Known in the Breaking of the Bread



*"When he was at table with them, he took the bread and blessed and broke it and gave it to them. And their eyes were opened, and they recognized him" (Luke 24:30–31).*

Go back to the road. By the time Jesus finished, the sun was going down and the two disciples had reached their village. He "acted as if he were going farther," and they begged him, "Stay with us, for it is toward evening and the day is now far spent" (24:28–29). So he came in. At the table, the guest did what only the host should do. He took the bread, blessed it, broke it, and gave it to them. And in that moment their eyes were opened. It was Jesus. Then he was gone.

Their first words to each other are worth memorizing: "Did not our hearts burn within us while he talked to us on the road, while he opened to us the Scriptures?" (24:32). Their hearts started burning before they knew who he was. It happened while he was explaining the Bible. That is what the Scriptures do

when Christ opens them. And that is the whole purpose of this study. We are going to learn dates, books, covenants, and kings, but the goal was never a head full of Bible facts. Cleopas already had a head full of facts. The goal is to meet the Person the whole story is about.

Then look at what they did. Seven miles is a long walk, and it was dark. They "rose that same hour and returned to Jerusalem" (24:33). They had been walking away from the city with their faces down. Now they went back to it with news. The road, the dark, and the seven miles were the same. What had changed was that they had seen him alive.

Now the part you most need to hear. When Jesus summed up the whole Bible for his disciples that night, he did not end with the cross and the resurrection. He went one more step: "that repentance for the forgiveness of sins should be proclaimed in his name to all nations" (24:47). All nations. That means the story does not stop at the edge of the page. It reaches all the way to where you are sitting right now. The God who made you, whom you have wronged in more ways than you can count, has made a way back to himself through the death and resurrection of his Son. The Lamb was provided. Forgiveness is offered in his name, and it is offered to you. He calls you to turn from your sin and trust him. That turning is what "repentance" means.

Maybe you are reading this as someone who has just come to faith. Then welcome home. You have stepped into a story that started long before you and will go on long after you, and you have a place in it. Maybe you are not sure yet what you believe. Then come and walk the road anyway. Bring your questions. Jesus was patient with two slow, confused, disappointed disciples. He will be patient with you. And if, somewhere along the way, the Scriptures begin to persuade you that Jesus is who he said he is, do not put him off. Turn to him, trust him, and ask him to receive you. He has promised, "whoever comes to me I will never cast out" (John 6:37).

## Living It: Six Practices for This Week

1 **Get a Bible you can read.** This study quotes the English Standard Version (ESV). Any faithful modern translation will do. Write your name in it. It is yours, and it is meant to be used.

2 **Read Luke 24 twice.** Read it once straight through. Then read verses 13–35 again slowly, and put yourself on the road. Which line stops you?

3 **Learn the four acts.** Creation, Fall, Redemption, Restoration. Say them out loud until you can explain each in one sentence to someone else.

4 **Mark three places.** Put a bookmark or ribbon at Genesis 1, Luke 24, and Revelation 21. Read the first two pages and the last two pages of the Bible side by side.

5 **Pray for an opened mind.** Before you read, ask the Lord to do for you what he did for the disciples in Jerusalem that night: "Then he opened their minds to understand the Scriptures" (Luke 24:45). Open mine, Lord.

6 **Memorize Luke 24:27.** "And beginning with Moses and all the Prophets, he interpreted to them in all the Scriptures the things concerning himself." It is the key to every lesson that follows.

**Before Lesson 2:** *Read Genesis 1–2 and Psalm 19. Lesson 2 asks the first question of the story: who is the God who is there?*

## The Road Ahead: Twenty-Six Lessons

This is where the series goes. Each unit is one stretch of the story. Every lesson follows the same pattern: where we are on the timeline, the passages to read, the story itself, where the two threads show up, how it points to Jesus, questions to talk through, and a verse to carry with you.

| Unit | Lessons |
|---|---|
| 1. Foundations | 1 The Story Jesus Told · 2 The God Who Is There · 3 Creation and the Image of God · 4 The Fall · 5 Ruin Spreads: Cain, the Flood, and Babel |
| 2. The Promise | 6 Abraham: The Call and the Covenant · 7 Isaac, Jacob, and Joseph |
| 3. Rescue and Covenant | 8 The Exodus and the Passover Lamb · 9 Sinai: The Law and the Covenant · 10 The Tabernacle: God Moves In · 11 Sacrifice and the Day of Atonement · 12 Wilderness and Conquest |
| 4. The Kingdom | 13 Judges and Ruth · 14 Saul, David, and a Forever King · 15 Solomon and the First Temple · 16 A Kingdom Divided, Prophets Sent · 17 Exile: The Temple Falls · 18 Return: The Second Temple and the Silent Years |
| 5. The King Arrives | 19 Who Jesus Is · 20 The Kingdom of God · 21 The Cross: The Final Lamb · 22 Resurrection and Ascension |
| 6. The Church and the End | 23 Acts: The Spirit and the Church · 24 Paul's Journeys and Letters · 25 Peter, James, John, and Hebrews · 26 Revelation and the New Creation |

## For Discussion

1. Before this lesson, how would you have described what the Bible is about in one sentence? How would you describe it now?
2. Cleopas had all the facts about Jesus and still walked away sad. Why do you think facts alone did not help him? Where have you seen that in your own life?
3. "We had hoped." Have you ever been disappointed with God because he did not do what you expected? How might knowing the whole story change the way you see that disappointment?
4. Jesus said the whole Old Testament was about him (Luke 24:27, 44). What difference does that make in how you approach books like Genesis or Leviticus?
5. Of the four acts (Creation, Fall, Redemption, Restoration), which one do you think people around you understand least? Which one do you most need to hear right now?
6. Read Genesis 2:8–10 and Revelation 22:1–5 side by side. What do you notice? What is the same, and what is better at the end?

7. The two disciples said their hearts burned while Jesus opened the Scriptures (Luke 24:32). What would it look like for you to come to this study expecting to meet him, and not only to learn about him?

## Sources & For Further Study


- Augustine, *Quaestiones in Heptateuchum* 2.73: "in Vetere Novum lateat, et in Novo Vetus pateat."
- Westminster Confession of Faith (1646), 7.5–6, on the one covenant of grace under law and gospel.
- On διερμηνεύω: Bauer, Danker, Arndt, and Gingrich, *A Greek-English Lexicon of the New Testament* (BDAG), 3rd ed., s.v.; New Testament uses at Luke 24:27; Acts 9:36; 1 Cor. 12:30; 14:5, 13, 27.
- On the dating of the temple and the Exodus: 1 Kings 6:1; Edwin R. Thiele, *The Mysterious Numbers of the Hebrew Kings* (for the chronology of the kings); the Babylonian Chronicle (for Jerusalem's first capture in 597 BC, from which the 586 date is counted).
- James Ussher, *Annales Veteris Testamenti* (1650). William Henry Green, "Primeval Chronology," *Bibliotheca Sacra* (1890).
- For further reading: Graeme Goldsworthy, *Gospel and Kingdom*; Vaughan Roberts, *God's Big Picture*; Geerhardus Vos, *Biblical Theology*.





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